

Where the writing reaches for a phrase

Tom,

I have read every page of the site and all four of the public documents on the What the Work Looks Like page, looking for one thing only: places where the writing uses a stock phrase or a borrowed image instead of saying the thing directly.

Two things worth saying before the list. First, the copy is a long way above the standard for this sector. The voice is distinctive, the sentences are short, there is no jargon fog, and the case studies say what actually happened including the parts that went wrong. That is rare and it is the reason the site works. Second, almost everything below is a small edit. None of it is a rewrite.

The list is ranked from most noticeable to least, so if you only change the first ten items you will have taken out most of it.

The two habits underneath the individual phrases

These matter more than any single line, because they repeat.

1. The "not X, it is Y" construction

It appears at least fourteen times across the site and the documents: *not an audit, a half-time team talk; not a report telling the client what is wrong; not bureaucracy, it is how good ideas turn into progress; not as an adviser but with the chequebook in his hand; not because everything had always gone right, but because; the problem is not a lack of effort; the purpose is not more paperwork.*

One or two of these land well. Fourteen reads as a verbal tic, and it is one of the phrasings readers now most associate with machine-written text. My suggestion is to keep two or three across the whole estate and rewrite the rest as plain statements.

2. "Real", "properly", "actually"

Roughly one sentence in three carries one of these: *real businesses, real momentum, real assets, real commercial opportunities, look properly, sold properly, went through everything properly, how it actually operates, who actually delivers.*

They are part of the voice, so I would not remove them all. But they tend to sit where a specific fact should be. *Built from running real businesses for over 20 years* says less than "Twenty years running a taxi firm, a garage and a marine services business" does. Where you can swap one of these words for a detail, the sentence gets stronger.

One thing I have deliberately left alone. The testimonials from Nick, Tristan, Dan and Simon contain a few stock phrases of their own. They are direct quotations, so they should stay exactly as they are. Editing a client's words to sound less ordinary would be worse than the phrase.

Tier one: the sustained metaphors

These sit at the top because they are not single phrases. They run for whole pages, and the reader has to keep the metaphor in their head while also following the commercial argument.

NO.	WHAT IT SAYS	WHERE	WHAT IT IS TRYING TO SAY
1	<i>Half-Time Team Talk, assuming I do not get substituted before the final whistle, The Second Half, Final Whistle, Meetings need a finish line, first-team money, Red Card, The Scoreboard</i>	Half-Time Team Talk (throughout), Stadium document, site card 01	Findings from the middle of a review. What I have seen so far, and what I would change next.
2	<i>The Mind That Built the Business Keeps Building the Next Stadium; builds the full stadium before checking whether anyone is coming to the match; a full stadium drawn in less than an hour; build the crowd first, then build the next stand</i>	Stadium document: title, cover, p6, closing page	The business designs the complete system before testing whether there is demand for the simple version. Prove the small thing works, then expand it.
3	<i>The Tom Rules, Tom Verdict, Tom decision</i>	Stadium document, on nine separate pages	"Recommendation" or "My view". Referring to yourself in the third person reads as self-promotion, which undercuts the authority the rest of the document has earned.
4	<i>magic bullet; section heading The Other Magic Bullets</i>	Stadium document p2, p8	Single purchases expected to solve a structural problem.
5	<i>CRM merry-go-round</i>	Stadium document p3, p4	Four changes of CRM direction in a short period, with no settled system at the end of it.
6	<i>third-party moonshot</i>	Stadium document p3	A very large proposal with no funding, users or defined role for the client.

A word in defence of the football conceit. It is doing real work. It softens a very direct set of findings, and "half-time" genuinely frames the document as mid-course rather than a verdict, which is exactly what you say it is. The problem is volume, not concept. If the running metaphor were confined to the title and the closing paragraph, and every heading in between were plain, the effect would be stronger, not weaker.

The stadium document is the harder call, because the metaphor is in the title, the cover quote, a page heading and the final line. If you keep it anywhere, keep it on the cover.

Tier two: the website

NO.	WHAT IT SAYS	WHERE	PLAIN VERSION
7	So why does it still feel like constant firefighting?	Home, hero	So why are you still solving the same problems every week?
8	Tell us about your fires	Home, hero button	Tell us what is going on. You already use that line everywhere else and it is better.
9	That gut feeling is not guesswork / Listen to what feels wrong	Useful Thinking	Your instinct is built on experience. It is worth taking seriously when it disagrees with the numbers.
10	Use the numbers. Do not worship them.	Useful Thinking	Use the figures, but do not let them override what you know about the business.
11	The 1% that feels like 100%	Useful Thinking	One small part of the business is making all of it feel heavier than it should.
12	It adds up. It always adds up.	Useful Thinking, fixed overheads	Unused subscriptions cost more than most owners expect.
13	We have never walked into a business and not found money being spent on things nobody uses	Useful Thinking, fixed overheads	In every review so far we have found money going out on things nobody uses. The double negative also makes the claim harder to read than it needs to be.
14	the stuff nobody cancelled	Useful Thinking	Subscriptions nobody has reviewed.
15	The numbers usually have a different story to tell than the owner has been hearing	What We Do, step 03	The accounts often show something different from what the owner has been told.
16	where the money is leaking	What We Do, step 03	Where costs are higher than they should be.
17	The Margin That Was Always There	What We Have Done, case 03	Margin the business was already earning but could not see.
18	More revenue from the same workload. That is what structure does.	What We Have Done, case 03	The same number of appointments produced more profit, because time, bookings and money were finally tracked together.
19	without adding a single extra appointment; without a single penny of external investment	What We Have Done, cases 02 and 03	With no extra appointments. With no outside investment. The word "single" is doing the emphasis that the fact already does.
20	At 22 Tom sold his PlayStation, his TV and his bike	About Us	At 22 Tom sold what he owned and borrowed the rest to buy a struggling taxi firm. The PlayStation is doing a lot of work in that sentence, and readers know it.
21	There was no plan B, just a gut feeling and plenty to learn	About Us	He had no fallback and very little experience.

NO.	WHAT IT SAYS	WHERE	PLAIN VERSION
22	grew fifteenfold and eventually sold for seven figures	About Us	Give the real multiple and the year. "Seven figures" reads as a boast where a number would read as evidence.
23	small daily decisions make or break a company	About Us	The routine decisions are what determine whether a business works.
24	This business exists because we learned the hard way	About Us	We started this because we made these mistakes ourselves.
25	not as an adviser but with the chequebook in his hand	What We Have Done, case 02	Tom took direct financial control rather than an advisory role.
26	From insolvency risk to a marketable asset	What We Have Done, case 02	Two years later it was profitable, and it sold.
27	Like most real business stories, it was not a clean straight line	What We Have Done, case 01	The business nearly failed before it recovered.
28	A business can be growing and still be drifting away from what actually makes it work	What We Have Done, case 01	Growth in the wrong area can weaken the part that earns the money. This one is close to earning its place; it is the "actually" that tips it.
29	The perspective we needed is the one we now bring	About Us	We do for other owners what nobody did for us.
30	Strategy, tested against real experience	About Us, Oxford panel	The sentence directly beneath it already says this. Cut the strapline and keep the fact.
31	Sometimes the idea does not need killing. It just needs parking somewhere safe.	Useful Thinking	You may not need to stop it. You may only need to pause it.
32	puts you back in control of your own business	Useful Thinking, cash flow	Weekly cash figures let you act before the money has gone.
33	By the time you get that information quarterly, the damage is already done	Useful Thinking, cash flow	Quarterly accounts arrive too late to act on.
34	The Holiday Test, The Pricing Gamble, The To Do Trap, The Step Back Test, The Decision Test, The Value Test	Useful Thinking, owner dependency	Six good questions with brand names attached. The questions are strong on their own. Naming them makes them look like a product.
35	is there an element of holding your finger in the air	Useful Thinking	Are you costing jobs properly, or estimating?
36	Is your to do list just wishful thinking	Useful Thinking	Do you get through your list, or does the day get taken over by other people?
37	so it works properly without taking over their lives	About Us	So the business does not need the owner for everything.
38	You cannot respect what someone has built without first taking the time to understand it	Home, what we do	We look at how the business works before suggesting any changes. The point is good; the sentence is grander than it needs to be.

Tier three: the documents

These are constructions rather than metaphors, and they are the mildest group. Several are close to fine on their own; they stand out because there are so many of them in a short space.

NO.	WHAT IT SAYS	WHERE	PLAIN VERSION
39	It does not have an ideas problem. It has a finish line problem.	Stadium document p2	Ideas are not in short supply. Finished work is.
40	Ideas are cheap. Follow-through is the expensive bit.	Stadium document p12	Starting is easy. Finishing takes the time and the money.
41	Ambition is not the problem.	Stadium document, closing page	The ambition is fine. Starting the next thing before the last one works is not.
42	The only question that earns the next pound; Where the next pound goes	Stadium document p2, p11	The test for approving new spending. Spending priorities.
43	The Hidden Bill; the invoice is only the visible part of the cost	Stadium document p10	The invoices are not the whole cost. Staff time and delayed campaigns cost more than the software did. This one is close to earning its keep, because the point is genuinely counter-intuitive.
44	nine starts for every finish	Stadium document p2	Fine if nine is the real count. If it is rhetorical, give the real one.
45	What is the kill rule?	Stadium document p12, eight questions	At what point do we stop this?
46	one clean client journey from enquiry to conversion	Stadium document p4	One agreed process from first enquiry to paid work. "Journey" is the single most worn word in business writing.
47	weekly operating rhythm	90-Day Action Plan, action 2; Enactment Sheet	A fixed weekly meeting with a live action list. This is consultancy vocabulary, and it sits oddly in documents that are otherwise written in plain English.
48	It is not another report to read and file away	90-Day Action Plan, purpose	This is a working document rather than a report.
49	That is not bureaucracy. It is how good ideas turn into progress.	Half-Time Team Talk	This is not extra administration. It is what makes a decision stick.
50	Those are real assets, not polite filler.	Half-Time Team Talk	These are genuine strengths, not flattery.
51	It suffered because decisions never quite became decisions.	Half-Time Team Talk	No single bad call caused this. The decisions were never finalised. Worth noting that this line is one of the best in the document, and it only just crosses the line.
52	The next system will not rescue a process that has never been settled.	Stadium document p4	A new CRM will not fix a process nobody has agreed.

NO.	WHAT IT SAYS	WHERE	PLAIN VERSION
53	Treat one client as one client, not proof of a market; earn the right to call it a programme	Stadium document p7	One client is not evidence of demand. Call it a programme once the referrals repeat.
54	That is fixable. The business does not need reinventing.	Half-Time Team Talk	These are solvable problems.
55	A large plan can feel like progress.	Stadium document p9	A long document is not the same as work being done.

If you only do five things

- **Thin the football and stadium metaphors** down to the titles and the closing lines. Make every heading in between plain. This is by far the biggest single change and it affects both flagship documents.
- **Replace "Tom Verdict" and "The Tom Rules"** with "Recommendation" and "Rules before a project starts". The findings are strong enough that they do not need a byline on every page.
- **Cut the "not X, it is Y" construction** from fourteen uses down to two or three.
- **Change the hero:** "constant firefighting" and "Tell us about your fires" are the first two things a visitor reads, and they are the most worn phrases on the site. "Tell us what is going on" is already your best line. Use it in both places.
- **Swap "seven figures" and "real businesses" for actual numbers and actual names.** Specifics are more persuasive than emphasis, and you have the specifics.

None of this is urgent and none of it is doing you damage as it stands. It is the difference between copy that is clearly better than the competition and copy that sounds like nobody else could have written it.

Happy to make any of these changes directly, or to leave the list with you and change nothing.

Nat